

Acer Aspire One 751H

In many ways, the Acer Aspire One 751h, the company's first 11.6-inch (29.5 cm) netbook, is an improvement over the D250 I had reviewed. With Aspire One, users get an extra inch of screen real estate, a roomier keyboard, and more than five hours of battery life (on Ubuntu Netbook Remix). But although it's larger, the 751h has a weaker processor. The result is a netbook that looks and feels great but offers a slower performance than other machines in its class.

Design

If you've seen the 10-inch Aspire One D250, the 11.6-inch version will look familiar. It also has a glossy black lid with Acer's metal logo in the lower corner; the lid picks up fingerprints fairly easily. There's also a grey palm rest and keyboard deck with a black keyboard and thin bezel to match.

Thus, the overall effect is conservative, but not cheap-looking. The real cornerstone of the Aspire One's design is not the colour scheme anyway, but its thinness. Whereas its competitors, such as the ASUS Eee PC 1005HA, are 1.4 inches (3.5 cm) thick and weigh close to 1.5 kg (the 1005HA weighs 1.4 kg), the Aspire One has a minimal footprint of 11.2x7.8x1.0 inches (28.4x19.8x2.5 cm).

The only catch is its six-cell battery juts out at the back, whereas some netbooks, such as the Eee PC 1005HA, have comparable battery sizes that fit more flush with the system.

The keyboard

The Aspire One 751h has raised keys with a slightly textured feel. The layout is close to full size, and we appreciate that the right *Shift* key is of full size and in the proper place. Touch typists will have no problem with this netbook, but we noticed that the keyboard flexed as we pounded out responses to IMs.

The touchpad and touch button

When we had reviewed the latest 10-inch Aspire One, we had complained about the tiny touchpad. With the 751h's slightly wider footprint, however, comes a wider touchpad (2.5 x 1.6 inches or 6.3 cm x 4.1 cm), which was a pleasant improvement over the D250's 2.0 x 1.5-inch (5.1 cm x 3.8 cm) pad.

Display and sound

One feature the 751h offers that most of its 10-inch competitors don't is a high-resolution screen. Whereas the 1005HA and Aspire One D250 have displays with 1024 x

600-pixel resolution, the AO751h's 11.6-inch display has a resolution of 1366 x 768. Those extra vertical pixels, in particular, mean you won't have to scroll down as often when you're viewing pages, a common inconvenience with netbooks.

The volume, as you would expect with a netbook, is weak. Music was predictably tinny, but no worse than on other netbooks.

Ports and the webcam

The 751h has a standard selection of ports: three USB ports, VGA output, an Ethernet jack, headphone and mic ports, and a 4-in-1 memory card reader. The memory card reader, VGA and one USB port are on the right side, and the rest are on the left.

The netbook comes with an embedded 1.3 mega-pixel webcam, is exceptionally bright and sports extremely high latency.

Processor

The AO751h has most of the components that a netbook normally features—1GB of RAM, a 160 GB hard drive, and either a 1.6-GHz or 1.66-GHz Intel Atom processor. However, this one sports a 1.33 GHz Intel Atom Z520 processor. Like many other netbooks, the 751h uses Intel's integrated GMA 500 graphics solution, with 384 MB of shared memory.

Battery life

The 751h has some tough competition in the battery life department. I found the 1005HA lasting nearly four hours on JoliCloud. The 751h lasted three and a half hours, which, given that Linux has absolutely messed up power management capabilities, is still an impressive score. It beats my official six-cell HP netbook's average by almost 90 minutes.

Verdict

If you're craving a little more screen real estate than the average netbook, along with a high-resolution display, the Acer Aspire One 751h combines several compelling features, such as hours of battery life and an exceptionally slim 1-inch silhouette. But if all you want is a netbook—and not necessarily an 11-inch one—there are several comparably priced (albeit, thicker) 10-inch models, such as the Dell Mini 10V and the ASUS 1005HA, which run faster and last even longer.

